



Kevin Reuter & Lucien Baumgartner

When Nouns Turn Negative

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Outline

1. Evaluative Concepts and Methodology
2. Conjoining Adjectives with Evaluative Adjectives: discriminatory, ignorant, rational
3. Conjoining Adjectives with Nouns: The case of “Conspiracy Theory”
4. Pejoration and the Evaluative Absorption Model
5. Objections and Limitations

Evaluative Concepts

Thick concepts

- Dependent descriptive and evaluative dimension
- E.g., “rude”, “friendly”

Dual Character concepts

- Independent normative and descriptive dimension
- E.g., “artist”, “philosopher”

Value-associated concepts

- trigger positive or negative arousal
- E.g., “young”, “empty”

Thin concepts

- merely evaluative
- E.g., “good”, “terrible”

Methods for Studying Evaluative Content

Introspective Analysis

- Traditional philosophical or linguistic reflection on whether a term is evaluative

Psychological & Experimental Methods

- Rating tasks, reaction-time measures capturing perceived evaluativity.

Linguistic Methods

- Contradiction, Cancellability, Embedding, Intensifiers

Advantages of Corpus-Based Approaches

Naturalistic Evidence

- Captures how evaluative terms are actually used in spontaneous language, not just how speakers think they are used.

Scale and Representativeness

- Enables analysis of thousands of contexts across time, genres, and registers.

Quantifiable, Reproducible Results

- Supports statistical testing of evaluativity, and the exact and qualitative replication of results

But how? Adjectives are Key

Adjectives carry overt evaluative force

- Many adjectives (good, bad, fair, rude) directly express approval or disapproval.
- However, many more adjectives are only *used* evaluatively (Stojanovic, 2015)

Adjectives are flexible and compositional

- Combine flexibly with nouns, other adjectives, and verbs (adverbially) in most contexts

Adjectives occur frequently and broadly

- Huge prevalence of adjectives in adjectival and predicative position

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“And” - Conjunction

The conjunction «and» standardly connects adjectives having the same polarity (Elhadad & McKeown 1990). The following conjunctions sound natural:

- «generous and lovely» - > have the same positive polarity
- «rude and arrogant» - > have the same negative polarity

In contrast, these conjunctions sound odd:

- «generous and arrogant» - > have opposite polarity
- «rude and lovely» - > have opposite polarity

Philosophical Concepts

Certain (philosophical) concepts spark lively debates on whether that concept is purely descriptive or (at least partially) evaluative, e.g.,

- discriminatory (Lippert-Rasmussen 2006, Willemsen et al. 2024),
- ignorant (Le Morvan 2021, Pritchard 2021).
- rational (Broome 2020, Worsnip 2022, Kieseewetter 2017)

Discriminatory

Evaluative Conjunction Hypothesis:

If discriminatory has a strong evaluative dimension, we expect that people conjoin other evaluative terms of the same polarity with our target adjective. Thus,

- “discriminatory and unjust” should be typical and very common
- whereas “discriminatory and careful” should be less common and atypical.



Discriminatory

“discriminatory” does not
behave like a descriptive term

discriminatory		selective	
Term	Number	Term	Number
unfair	556	potent	422
arbitrary	443	careful	139
racist	373	cautious	85
divisive	173	narrow	84
hateful	172	sensitive	55
unconstitutional	153	efficient	46
unjust	145	active	40
offensive	119	biased	39
sexist	91	partial	37

Average SentiValue: -.512

Average SentiValue: +.109

Ignorance

- **Descriptive Account:** A subject S is ignorant of the fact that p iff S does not know that p (Le Morvan 2012, 2019).
- **Normative Account:** An individual S is ignorant of the fact that p iff:
(i) S does not know that p & (ii) S ought to know (Pritchard 2021)

Evaluative Conjunction Hypothesis:

If 'ignorant of' has a strong normative dimension, we expect that people conjoin other evaluative / normative terms of the same polarity with our target adjective.



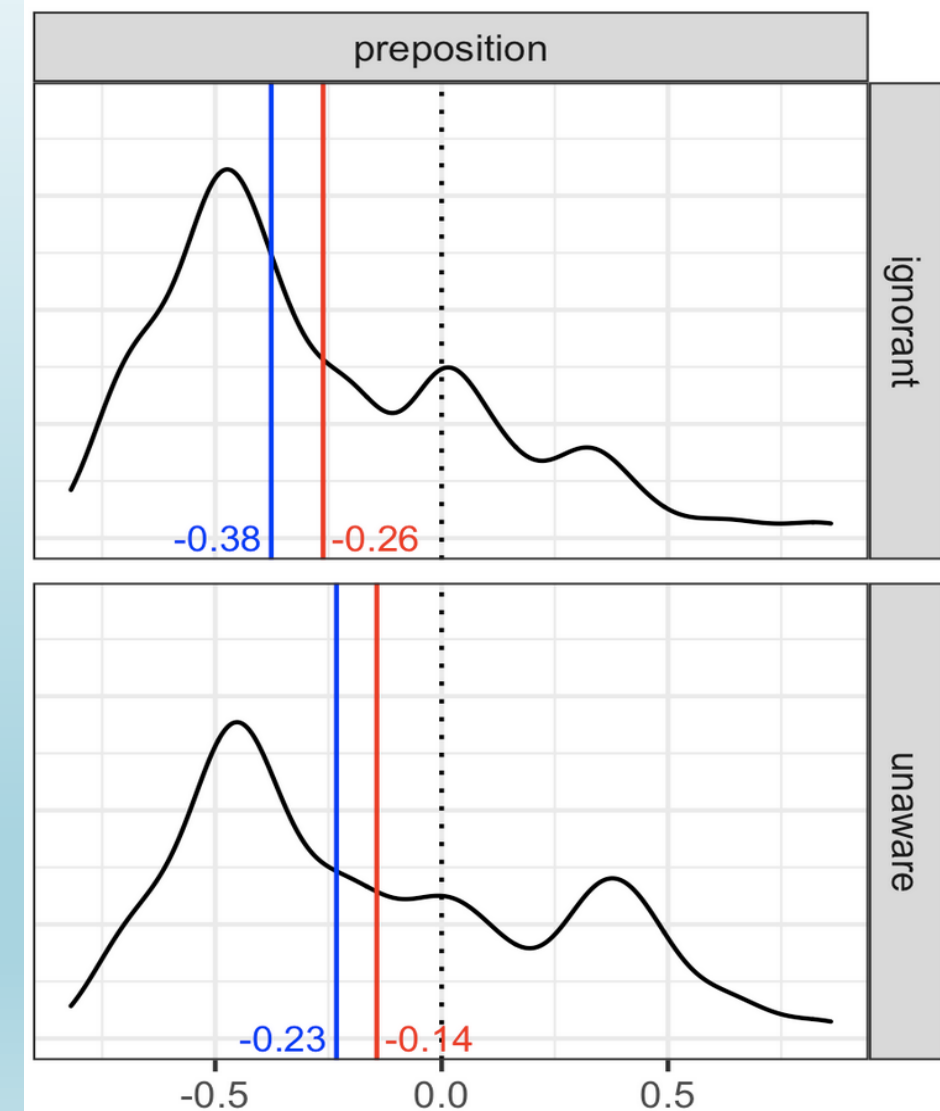
Ignorance

“arrogant and ignorant of p”, “lazy and ignorant of p”	should be common
“easygoing and ignorant of p”, “content and ignorant of p”	should be less common.

- Include a suitable control condition: “unaware of p” (syntactic reasons)
- Collect laypeople’s use of “ADJ and ignorant of”, as well as “ADJ and unaware of” from the social media website Reddit
- Final Corpus: 1626 comments for “Adj and ignorant of p” and 1748 comments for “Adj and unaware of p”
- Annotate the conjoined adjectives with sentiment values from the SentiWords dictionary (Baccianella et al. 2010)

Results

x and ignorant of			x and unaware of		
Term	Number	Percentage	Term	Number	Percentage
stupid	116	7.13	ignorant	103	5.89
naive	87	5.35	young	89	5.09
dumb	59	3.63	stupid	59	3.38
selfish	53	3.26	dumb	58	3.32
young	43	2.64	naive	46	2.63
short-sighted	42	2.58	asleep	44	2.52
wrong	42	2.58	unskilled	44	2.52
arrogant	41	2.52	aware	40	2.29
(close-, narrow-, simple-) minded	36	2.21	new	38	2.17
uneducated	29	1.78	innocent	29	1.66
racist	26	1.60	confused	27	1.54
blind	20	1.23	uneducated	27	1.54
lazy	20	1.23	selfish	26	1.49
dismissive	18	1.11	unconscious	24	1.37
rude	18	1.11	blind	23	1.32
unaware	18	1.11	stationary	22	1.26
disrespectful	17	1.05	incompetent	21	1.20
innocent	17	1.05	happy	20	1.14
uninformed	17	1.05	old	19	1.09
delusional	14	0.86	delusional	18	1.03
	733	45.08		777	44.45



Intermediate Conclusion

- discriminatory (Lippert-Rasmussen 2006, Willemssen et al. 2024),
- ignorant (Le Morvan 20213, Pritchard 2021).
- rational (Broome 2020, Worsnip 2022, Kiesewetter 2017)

The Evaluation Conjunction Hypothesis allows us to investigate the evaluative nature of a range of interesting terms in their adjectival form.

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What about nouns?

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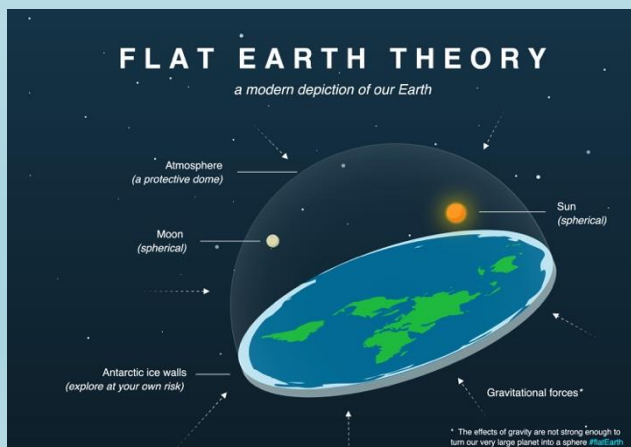
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What about nouns?

Many philosophically interesting terms are often debated in noun or verb form, not so much in their adjectival form (often it does not exist or is uncommon)

- “Knowledge” and “to know”. No common adjectival form
- “Conspiracy Theory”. No adjectival or verb form
- “Causation” and “to cause”. More common and central than “causal”
- “Discrimination”. Might mean something slightly different than the adjectival form

Various Conspiracy Theories



Purely Descriptive Definitions

Conspiracy theory, n.: the **theory** that an event or phenomenon occurs as a result of a **conspiracy** between interested parties. (Oxford Dictionary)

“The term “conspiracy theory” refers to a **theory** or explanation that features a **conspiracy** among a group of agents as a central ingredient.” (Pauly, IEP)

Conspiracy theory: a **theory** that explains an event or situation as the result of a **secret plan** by usually powerful people or groups (Brittanica Dictionary)

“That is, conspiracy theories are **theories**—in the explanatory sense—about **conspiracies**.”
(Dentith, 2022)

Corpus Study: Getting at the evaluative use

Research Question: Is the term 'conspiracy theory' used predominantly evaluative?

Evaluative Modification Hypothesis:

If 'conspiracy theory' is indeed an evaluative term, people will frequently use evaluative adjectives before the term 'conspiracy theory'.

Examples:

'stupid conspiracy theory' & 'wild conspiracy theory'	Very Common
'interesting conspiracy theory' & 'complex conspiracy theory'.	Not very common

Development over Time

2010-2016		2019-now	
Term	Number	Term	Number
good	43	baseless	493
popular	28	debunked	385
bizarre	27	far-right	335
new	26	right-wing	236
online	21	false	198
big	15	unfounded	197
particular	14	new	144
elaborate	13	anti-semitic	135
paranoid	13	pro-trump	135
racist	12	racist	120
grand	10	bizarre	119
latest	10	popular	113
ridiculous	10	online	103
right-wing	10	discredited	101
false	9	wild	100
crazy	9	crazy	71
baseless	9	dangerous	70
great	8	antisemitic	59
political	8	latest	59
weird	8	good	58

- All positive and neutral terms are used less frequent (relatively speaking) within the last few years.
- Negative epistemic terms have risen starkly in use.

Objection

How do you know that the frequent use of adjectives before the noun really indicates that the noun has an evaluative meaning?

Why not think: The presence of evaluative adjectives shows the opposite: Because people need to use an evaluative adjective, this indicates that “conspiracy theory” itself is not evaluative.

A similar question might be asked about the conjunction of evaluative adjectives with our target adjectives (discriminatory, ignorant, rational), but I don't think this objection is plausible. BECAUSE: Conjoined adjectives don't modify each other but are co-ordinated

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Pejoration

Pejoration: a specific subtype of semantic change where a word's meaning shifts over time from a more neutral or even positive sense to one that carries negative, disparaging, or derogatory connotations. (Hilpert & Gries, 2016)

Pejoration: the tendency to semanticize the more negative connotations of a word (Traugott 2017, p.385)

"The details of such changes have been taken to show that meaning change is particular to individual words and that there are few generalities to be made." (ibid, p.385)

Pejoration and the Evaluative Absorption Model

If a noun has undergone pejoration, we should observe two complementary shifts in its adjectival context:

1. Adnominal Increase of Negative Adjectives: A rising frequency of negative adjectives directly modifying the noun.
2. Post-pejoration Reduction of Negative Adjectives: A decline in the use of negative adjectives modifying the noun once its negative sense has become integrated.

First Phase of Pejoration

When a noun begins to acquire a negative connotation, speakers reinforce it by adding explicitly negative modifiers (e.g., unjust discrimination).

- Speakers wishing to express a non-standard evaluative use must first make it explicit.
- The negative interpretation is not yet part of common ground; it needs signalling.
- Adding adjectives like “bad” or “unfair” flags the intended evaluative stance to the listener.
- Repeated pairing of a noun with negative adjectives helps conventionalize and entrench the evaluative meaning.

Second Phase of Pejoration

Once a noun's negative meaning becomes established, speakers no longer need to signal it explicitly. Consequently, negative adjectives appear less frequently before the noun.

Reason 1: The evaluation is now lexically encoded — extra modifiers become redundant (e.g., unjust discrimination).

Reason 2: Speakers prefer brevity — if the noun already conveys the full evaluative sense, qualifiers are dropped.

→ The evaluative meaning has become inherent and self-sufficient.

Case Studies of Pejoration

“information that is
transmitted”

propaganda



“information—often biased or
misleading—used to influence opinion”

“the act of handling or
managing by hand”

manipulation



“handling in a clever or unscrupulous
way for one’s own ends”

“the act of repeatedly
wearing down

harassment



“persistent, wrongful vexation or
intimidation of a person”

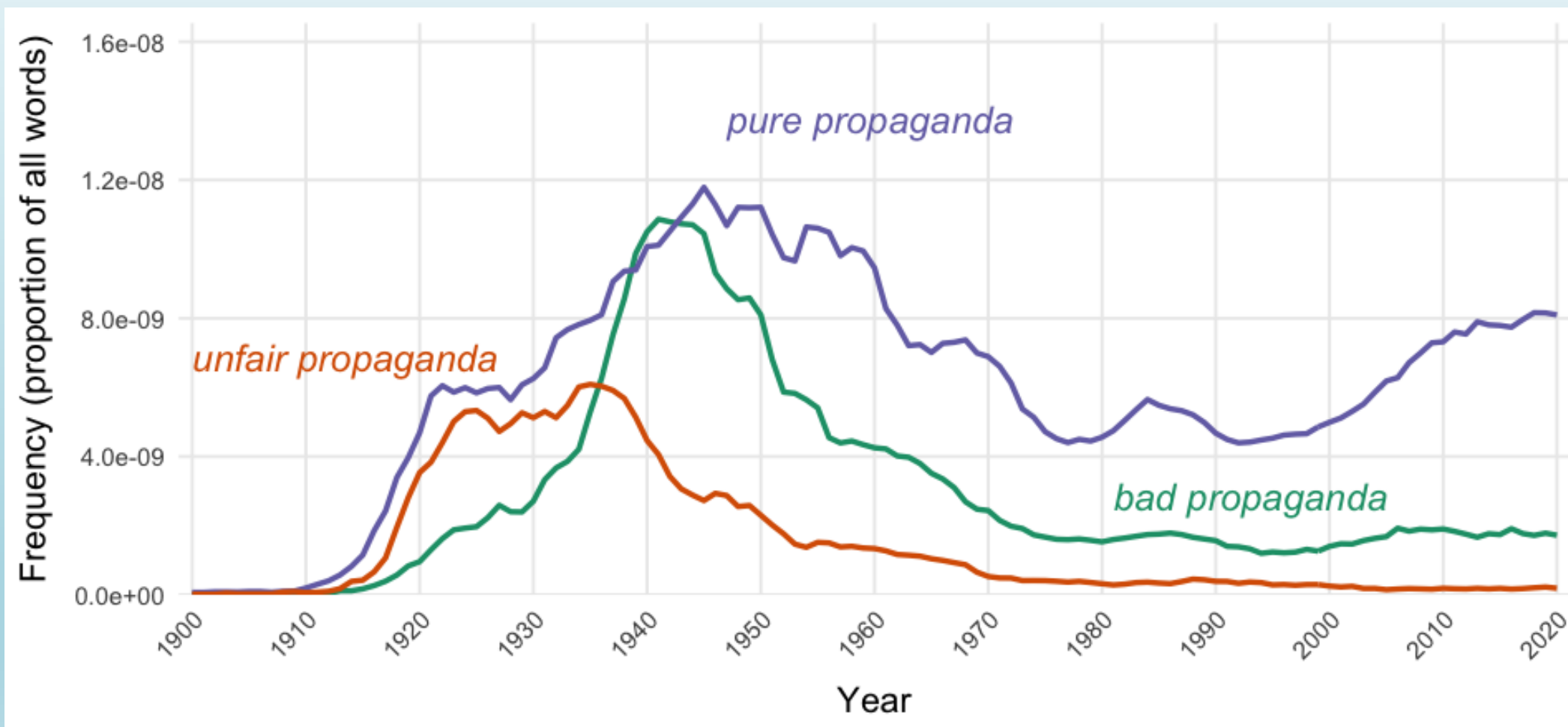
Selection of Evaluative Adjectives

Chosen adnominal adjectives: “unfair”, “unjust”, and “bad”.

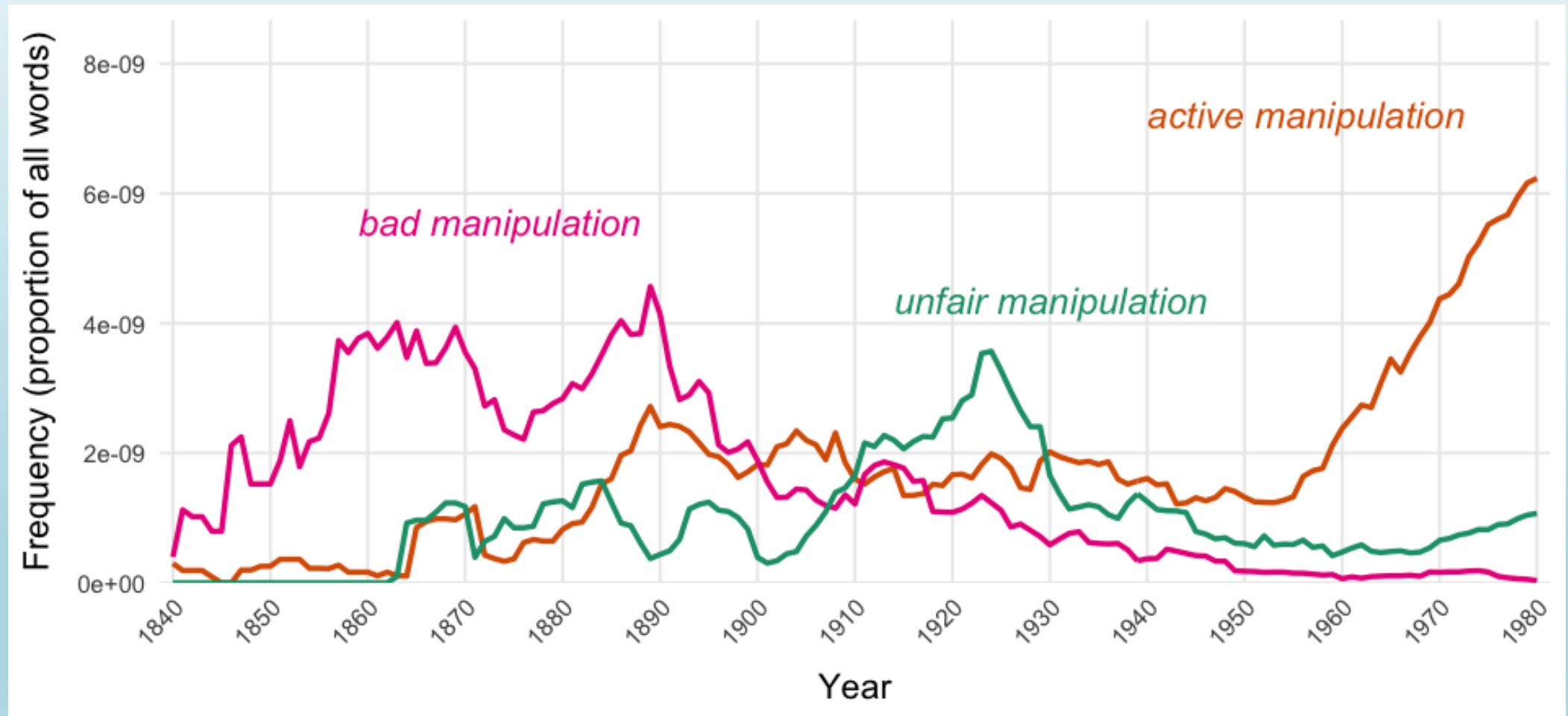
Reasons for selection:

- Unfair and unjust are thick evaluative terms— encode bias, partiality, and deviation from moral or legal norms.
- They show frequent collocations with all four target nouns (e.g., unfair discrimination, unjust propaganda), ensuring rich corpus data.
- Bad serves as a thin evaluative control, allowing comparison between general negativity and morally specific condemnation.

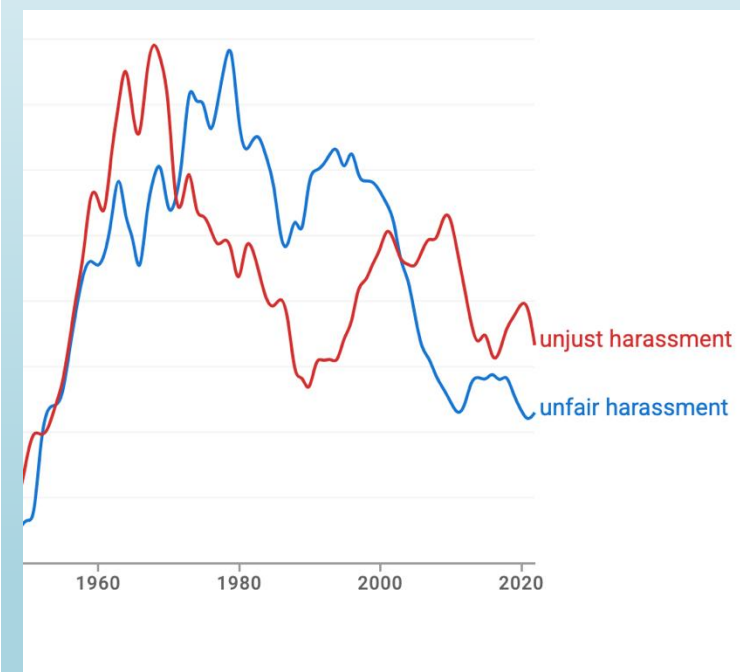
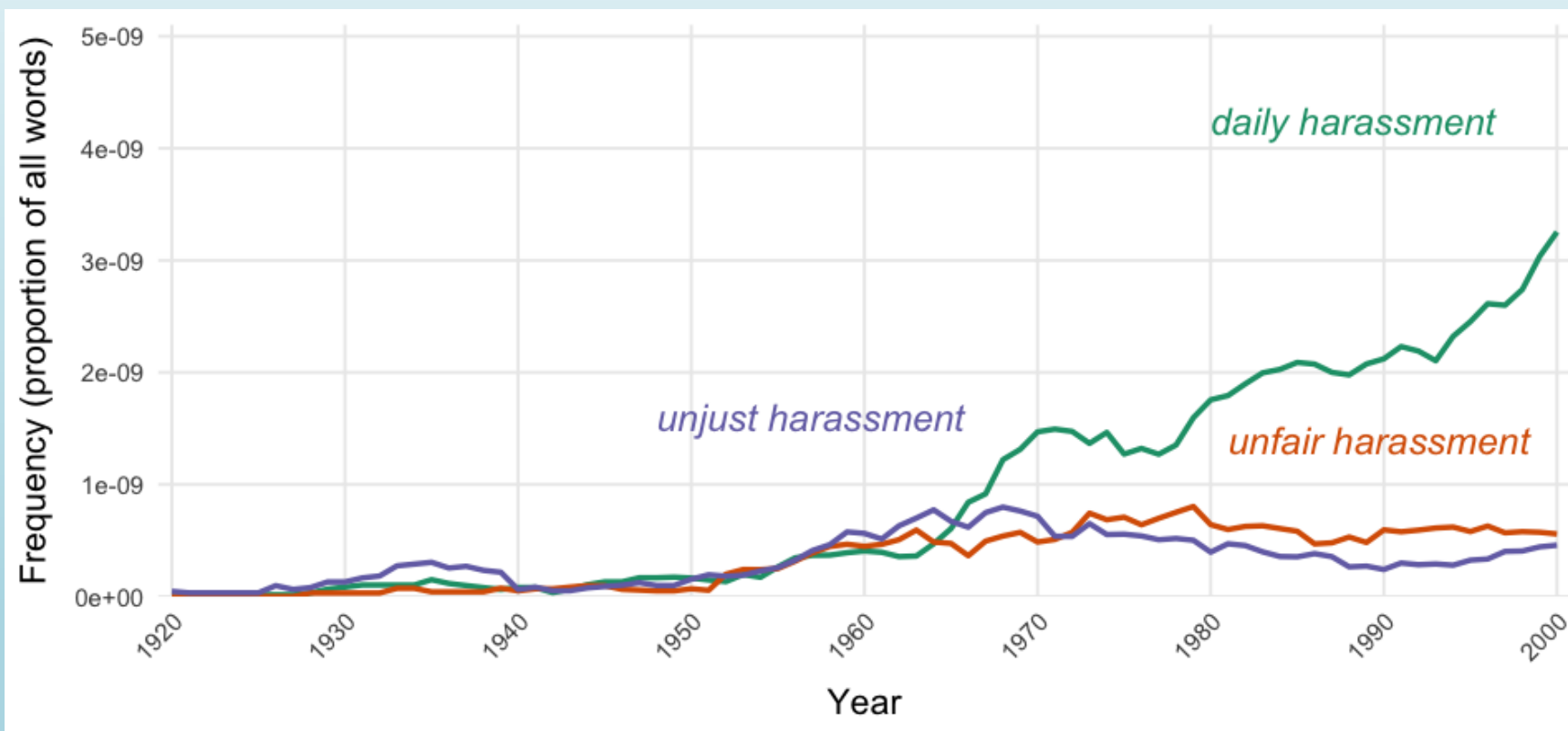
Propaganda



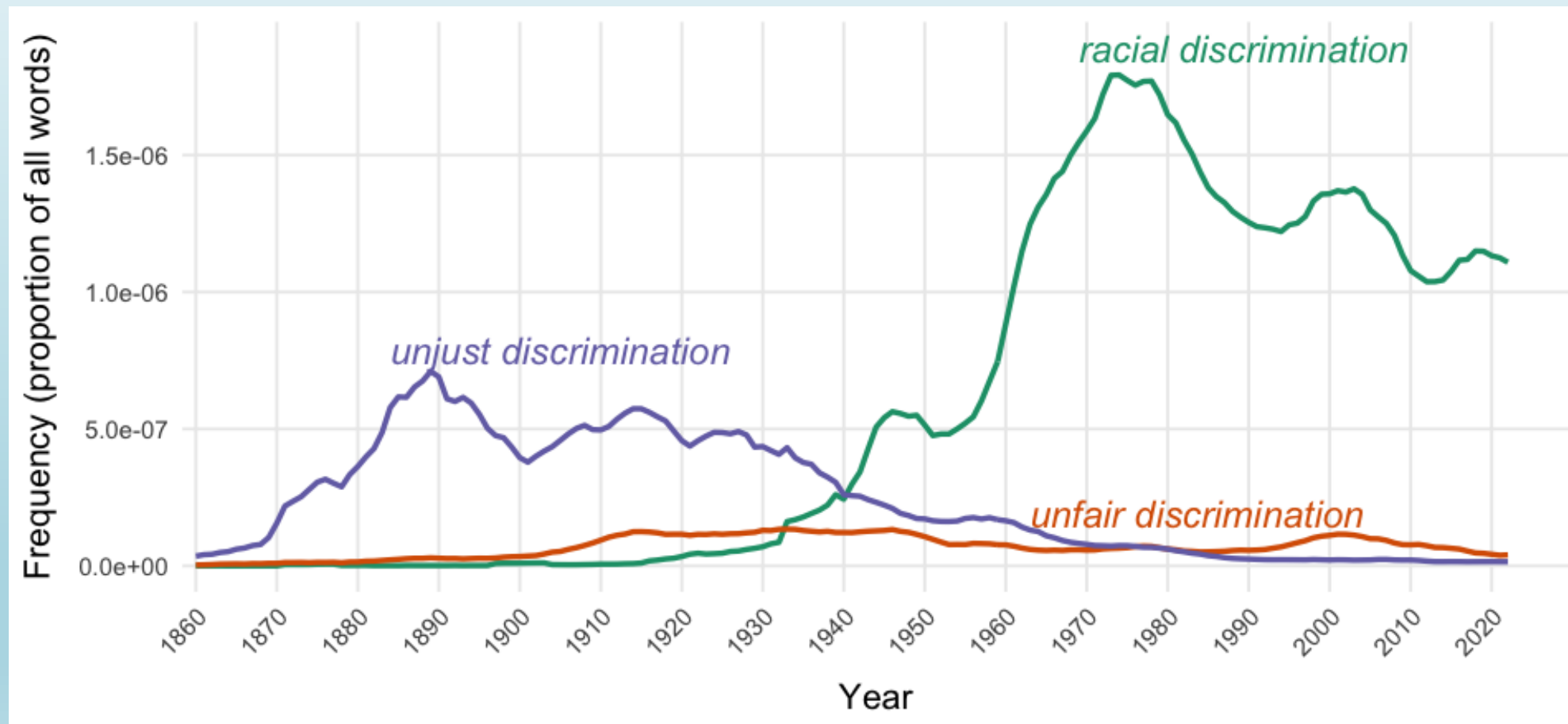
Manipulation



Harassment



What about discrimination ??



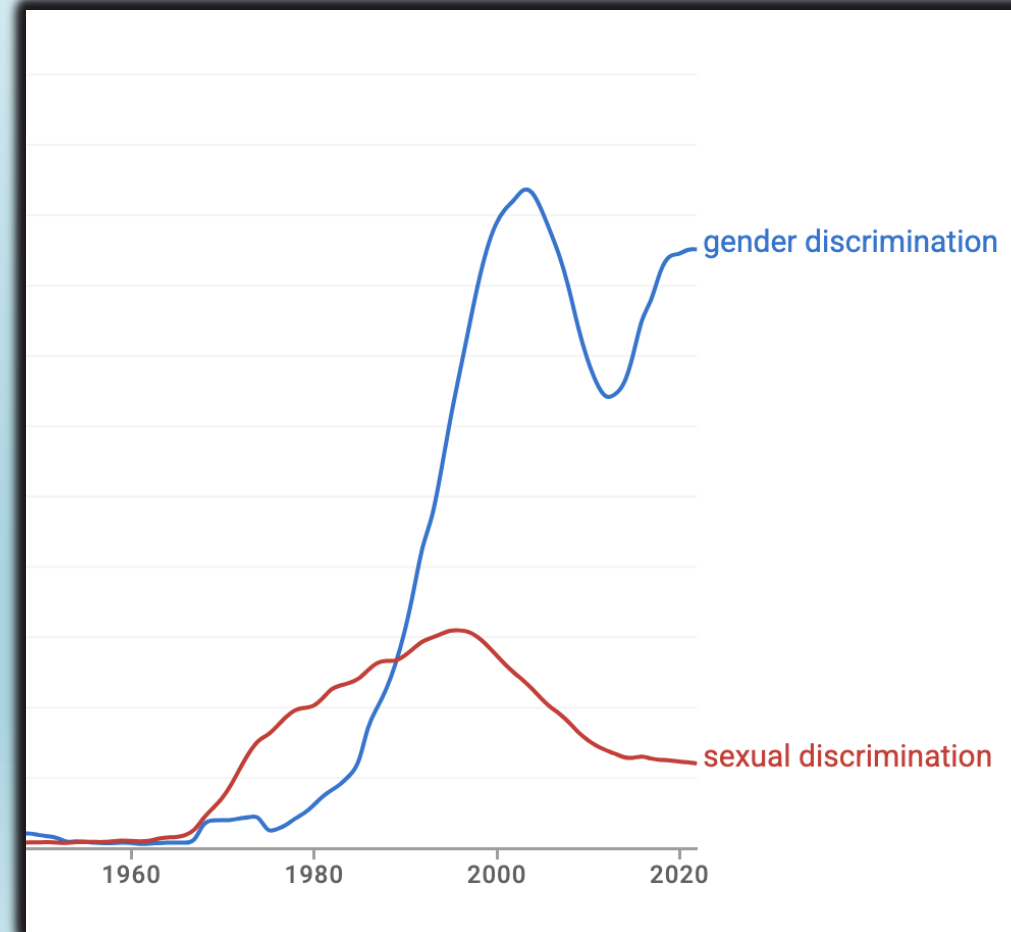
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Objection 1: Other Interpretations of the 2-Phases

Perhaps the rise and fall of evaluative adjectives like “unfair”, “unjust”, and “bad” is not a sign of evaluative absorption but can be explained in a different way.

Example: discrimination has not absorbed “sexual”, but rather people started to think that power structures are less about biological anatomy but rather socially constructed roles.



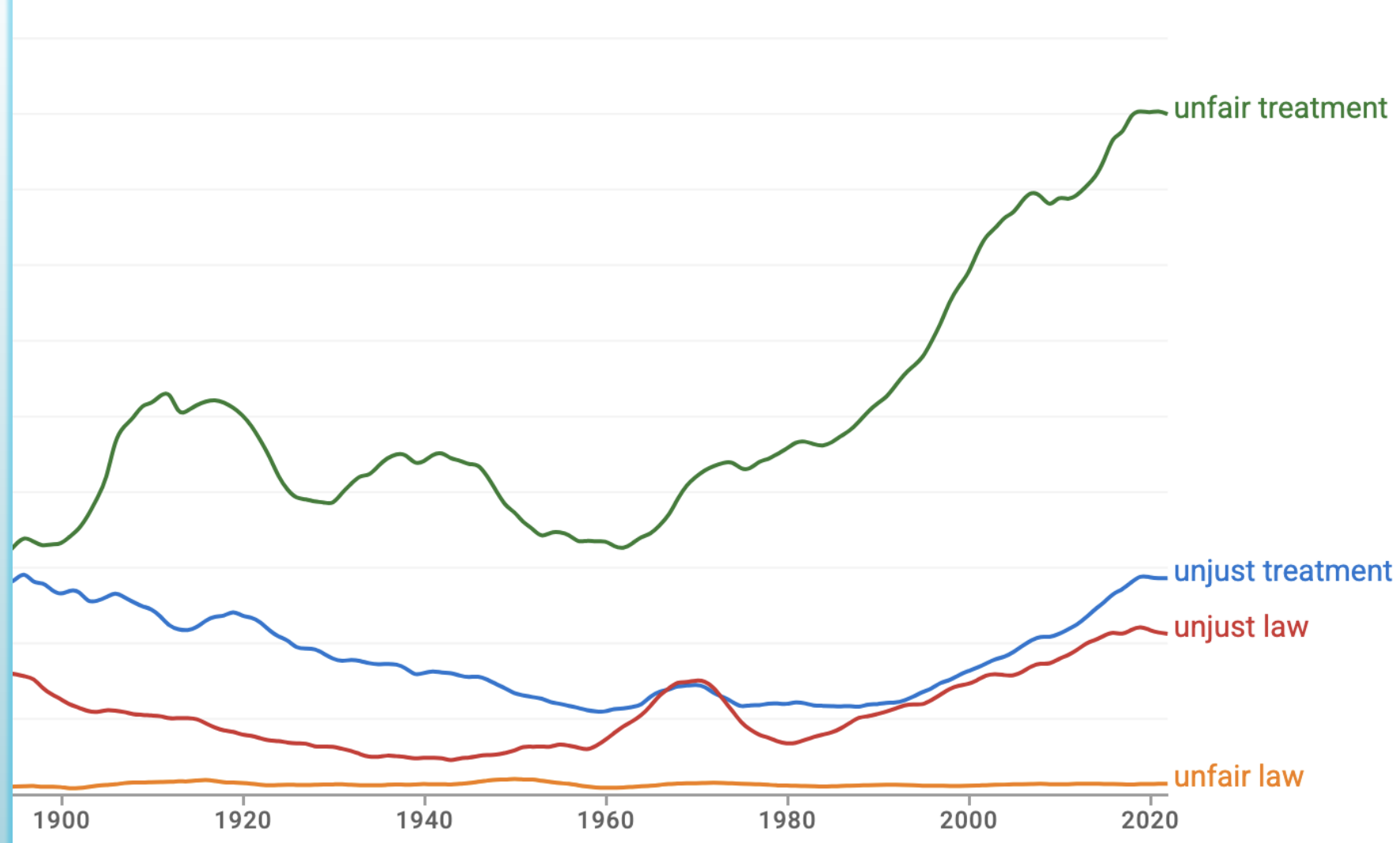
Solutions

In the end, we might need to rely on inferences to the best explanation. But there is more we can do:

Having a larger range of evaluative adjectives behaving similarly with a certain term, makes alternative explanations less likely.

And: Certain empirical hypotheses can be tested: For example, we should not see the same decline for a concept that hasn't absorbed evaluativity (e.g., unjust law or unjust treatment might persist longer).

Solutions



"treatment" and "law" are not negative evaluative terms. And they have not absorbed evaluativity.

Objection 2: Predicative uses of adjectives

While “unjust discrimination” is no longer common, we still find expressions like “discrimination is unjust” very frequently.

Attributive uses modify a noun within the phrase (unjust discrimination); their role diminishes once the noun itself encodes evaluation. **Predicative uses** explicitly express the speaker’s evaluative stance.

Overtly expressing one’s moral stance is a function that cannot be subsumed by the noun’s inherent evaluation alone.

Objection 3: Expanding the Set of Adjectives

Aren't we just cherrypicking?

Narrow adjective selection

Focused only on *unfair*, *unjust*, and *bad*, which may overemphasize specific evaluative dimensions.

Potential selection bias

Other evaluative modifiers might reveal different patterns of evaluative absorption or subtler moral distinctions.

Possible semantic drift

The meanings of *unfair* and *unjust* may themselves have evolved over time, affecting diachronic comparisons.

Limitations of NGRAM

Book-based bias

Overrepresents literary and academic writing, underrepresents spoken and social media language, where evaluative language often evolves first.

Limited contextual information

Cannot distinguish between different senses or uses of the same term.

No collocational insight

Tracks isolated word or phrase frequencies but ignores surrounding linguistic patterns and evaluative context.

Conclusions

- Corpus Studies using adjectives is a fruitful method to investigate the evaluative dimensions of adjectives and nouns
- The Evaluative Conjunction Hypothesis can be applied to target adjectives
- A high frequency of evaluative adjectives in adnominal position might NOT indicate that the target noun is evaluative
- Instead: It may be indicative of a two-phase process we call the evaluative absorption model. First, increase in evaluative adjectives. Second, decrease, after the evaluativity has become semanticized.